been no gray wolves in Yellowstone National Park for at least 70 years. American elk were common in the park, but there was just a single colony of beavers. That year, 31 wolves were introduced to the park and by 2001 their numbers had increased to more than 100, largely due to the abundance of elk for food.

The presence of wolves in the park forced the elk to become more mobile. Rather than over-grazing willow, aspen, and cottonwood trees in favored locations, the elk moved on, allowing plants to regenerate and provide a food source for other herbivores, such as beavers. Within 10 years, the number of beaver colonies increased from one to nine. Beaver dams helped revive wetlands, and wetland wildlife flourished. The increase in elk carcasses also benefited carrion-eaters—especially coyotes, red foxes, grizzly bears, Golden Eagles, Ravens, and Black-billed Magpies—as well as several smaller scavengers.

Jaguars are apex predators in South and Central American forests, preying on more than 85 species. Although there are very few jaguars in any given area, their impact on the numbers of other predators—such as caimans, snakes, large fish, and large birds—as well as herbivores, such as capybaras and deer, has a significant ripple-down effect on their ecosystem. Left unchecked, the herbivores could devour most of the plants and destroy the habitat on which so many other species depend.